Creation of Municipalities and Corporation

The development of local government in the British India may be traced in three distinct phases.

a. First phase (1688-1882)

Municipal government in India has been in existence since 1688 with the formation of Madras Municipal Corporation with a Mayor. Sir Josiah Child, one of the Directors of the East India Company was responsible for the formation of the Corporation. The Charter Act of 1793, established Municipal administration in the three presidency towns. According to the provisions of the Act of 1850, municipalities were formed in North Western Frontier provinces, Oudh and Bombay. Lord Mayo's famous Resolution of 1870 intended to afford opportunities for the development of self-government.

b. Second phase (1882-1920)

Ripon's Resolution on local Self – Government was a landmark in the history of local self-government. So Ripon is rightly regarded as the Father of Local Self – Government in India and his Resolution as the Magna–Carta of Local Self-Government.

c. Third phase (1920-1950)

The Government of India Act of 1919 introduced Dyarchy in the provinces. The Government of India Act of 1935 introduced Provincial Autonomy. With the attainment of Independence in 1947 India had the unique opportunity of making and moulding local government to meet the needs of the free nation.

Administration of the Presidency Towns

Towards the close of eighteenth century, a Parliamentary statute authorized the Governor General to appoint justices of the peace in these towns. After various trials a system of government was evolved for the three presidency towns which had the essential features like a large corporation with elected members, a strong independent executive authority with adequate safeguards for checking accounts and statutory provision for the performance of essential duties such as sanitation and water supply and collection of revenue etc.

Origin and Growth of Madras

The beginning of the city of Madras goes back to the earliest stages of British commercial enterprise in India. The English East India Company was started in 1600 A.D(C.E). Twelve years later, a Factory was set up at Surat on the West coast. Subsequently the search for textiles brought British merchants to have port on the east coast.

Presently Fort St. George is the power centre of Tamil Nadu State Government, extending across 172 sq. KM (66 sq. miles)

The English, after some efforts secured the privilege of building a factory at Masulipatnam. It was well protected from the monsoon winds. But then Masulipatnam was in the throes of a famine. In spite of every assurance of protection, English trade did not thrive at that place.

Then the English traders looked for a new site. Francis Day, the member of the Masulipatnam council and the chief of the Armagon Factory, made a voyage of exploration in 1637 with a view to choose a site for a new settlement. At last, he was given the offer to choose Madrasapatnam. Francis Day inspected the place and found it favourable to set up factory.

The official grant for the land was given by Damarla Venkatapathy Nayak, the deputy of the Raja of Chandragiri (12km west of Tirupathi). Damarla gave British a piece of land between Cooum river and the Egmore. In 1639 the deed was signed by English East India Company's Francis Day accompanied by his interpreter Beri Thimmappa and superior Andrew Cogan. By this Francis Day and

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